Unit 2 — Globalisation Debates

Track E · Klasse 12 · Niveau E (Basisfach / Leistungsfach)

Learning objectives I

- *I can read short pro and contra positions on globalisation and identify the empirical claim each side hangs on.*
- *I can use the vocabulary of contested-policy debate (*supply chain, inequality, externality, comparative advantage, regulatory race*).*
- *I can write a 350-word op-ed that holds two readings of globalisation in productive tension.*

Lead-in I

The class read a 2025 review piece in *The Economist* summarising twenty years of globalisation debates. The piece opened with a number — *world trade as a share of GDP rose from 39 % in 1990 to 60 % by 2008* — and a counter-number — *and has plateaued since*. The class spent the lesson learning to read those two numbers as the same fact.

Reading I

Reading — *Twenty Years of Globalisation*
World trade as a share of GDP rose from 39 % in 1990 to 60 % by 2008. It has plateaued since. The supporters of the post-1990 trade order point to the lifting of approximately one billion people out of extreme poverty over the same period — predominantly in East and South Asia. Critics respond that intra-country inequality in advanced economies grew sharply, that supply-chain fragility was severely under-priced before 2020, and that environmental externalities were systematically exported. Both sides hang on empirical claims that are roughly correct.

Vocabulary — globalisation debate
supply chain, comparative advantage, regulatory race / race to the bottom, externality,

Reading II

intra-country inequality, trade order, deindustrialisation, reshoring, near-shoring, friend-shoring, decoupling, fragmentation, geo-economic.

Practise I

Niveau E — controlled

1. Match: comparative advantage → trade theory; externality → unpriced cost; reshoring → moving production back home.
2. T or F: *world trade as a share of GDP* rose from 39 % to 60 % between 1990 and 2008; intra-country inequality fell in advanced economies during the same period.

Niveau E — productive

3. Build 4 sentences using 4 globalisation-debate terms.

Your turn I

Op-ed, 350 words. Hold two readings of globalisation in tension. Use 5 globalisation-debate terms + 2 academic hedges + 1 cleft + 1 *despite* / *given that*.

Sample

The two strongest arguments about post-1990 globalisation are both empirical and both roughly correct, which makes the debate harder, not easier. It is precisely the simultaneous truth of one billion people lifted out of extreme poverty and *intra-country inequality in advanced economies growing sharply* that has produced the curiously polarised politics of the 2020s. The available evidence suggests that comparative advantage worked broadly as the textbooks promised: countries specialised, output grew, and aggregate welfare in many regions improved. By

Your turn II

contrast, the distributional question — who, within a country, captured the gains — was systematically under-asked. Accordingly, supply-chain fragility was severely under-priced before 2020. Externalities were exported; the regulatory race to the bottom on labour and environmental standards was real. Given that the politics has now shifted toward reshoring, near-shoring, and friend-shoring, the more useful question is not *was globalisation good or bad?* but *what would the next two decades have to look like to capture the aggregate gains without exporting the costs?* The honest answer involves instruments that are not yet in place — carbon border adjustments, social-investment funds in regions hit by deindustrialisation, supply-chain redundancy buffers. Despite the loud debate, the interesting work is engineering, not slogans. Caution is warranted; complacency is not.

Reflect I

- I can identify the empirical claim each side hangs on.
- I can use 5+ globalisation-debate terms.
- I can write a 350-word op-ed holding two readings in tension.

Further reading / listening I

- Dani Rodrik, *Straight Talk on Trade* (accessible chapters).
- The Economist — globalisation special reports.